

Session 3: Heaven and Earth Come Together in Jesus

Key Takeaways

- The New Testament's view of the universe is really similar to that of the Hebrew Bible.
- Jesus' message was that he was joining Heaven, the sphere of God's reign, and Earth, the space of humanity, within himself.
- Humans are to partner with Jesus in bringing Heaven to Earth by contributing to human flourishing.

New Testament Views of Heaven and Earth

The Gospel of Matthew

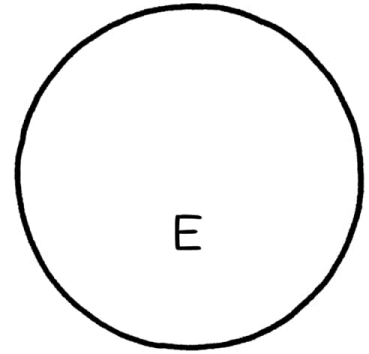
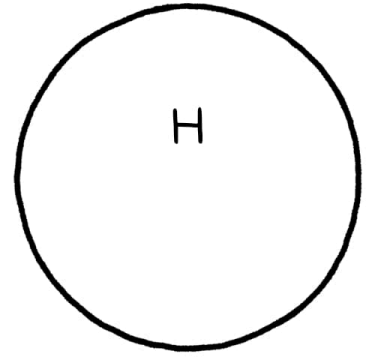
The following are examples of biblical cosmology in the Gospel of Matthew.

- Matthew 4:8: "a high mountain" from which Jesus can see all the kingdoms of the Earth
- Matthew 4:17: Kingdom of Heaven has come near
- Matthew 6:9-10: The Lord's prayer, God's Kingdom/will here on Earth as in Heaven
- Matthew 11:23: Capernaum not exalted up to Heaven but going down to *Sheol*/Hades
- Matthew 12:39-40: Sign of Jonah, belly of whale // "heart of the Earth"
- Matthew 12:42: Queen of the South comes "from the ends of the Earth"
- Matthew 28:16-20: On a mountain, the risen Jesus says, "All authority in Heaven and on Earth belongs to me"

HEAVENS = GOD'S SPACE

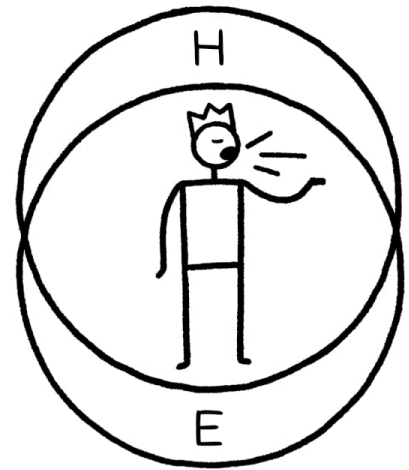
EARTH = HUMAN'S SPACE

WATERS = "NOBODY'S" SPACE



The Overlapping of Heaven and Earth. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

HEAVENS = GOD'S SPACE
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Jesus Is the Overlap Between Heaven and Earth. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

The Letters of Paul

The following are examples of biblical cosmology in the letters of Paul.

- Philippians 2:9-10: The exalted Jesus was raised high so every knee will bow “in Heaven, on Earth, and under the Earth.”
- Ephesians: 1:19-22: Jesus’ resurrection exalted him to “sit at his right hand in the heavenly places.”
- Ephesians 2:1-7: We have been raised from the dead and “raised up and seated with him in the heavenly places.”
- 2 Corinthians 12:1-4: Paul talks about “a guy I know” (himself) who had a vision and apocalypse where he ascended up to the “third Heaven.”

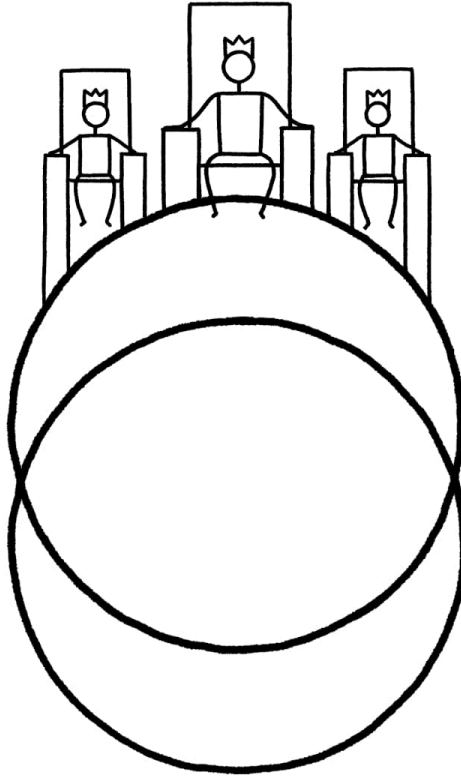
The Book of Revelation

The following are examples of biblical cosmology in the the book of Revelation.

- Revelation 21:1-3: A new Heaven and Earth, a city descending from Heaven (presumably the new one coming to a new Earth), but it’s called a tabernacle
- Revelation 21:10: The city coming down again, described as a temple-Jerusalem-garden-throne of God

What is going on in these passages? Over time, it became clear that the authors of the Hebrew Bible, Jesus, and the apostles imagined a universe that is very different from our modern conception of the universe.

It is crucial to understand the Bible on its own terms, which may require unlearning and relearning the biblical conception of the cosmos, that is, Heaven and Earth.



The Final Overlapping of Heaven and Earth. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

Reflection Question

The New Testament's view of the universe is really similar to that of the Hebrew Bible. Why does this matter when it comes to understanding Jesus and his message?